Learning Heuristics for the Gapped Longest Common Subsequence Problem

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Abstract. TODO

1 Introduction

The *Longest Common Subsequence Problem* (LCSP) [1] is a well-known combinatorial optimization problem with numerous applications in computational biology, particularly in the analysis of molecular sequences. Given an arbitrary set of input sequences $S = \{s_1, \ldots, s_m\}$ over an alphabet Σ, the goal is to determine the longest possible subsequence common to all $s_i \in S$. In recent decades, many practically motivated variants of the LCSP have been proposed by considering additional structural or biological constraints such as the constrained, arc-preserving, repetition-free version [4, 6], among others. In this work we study the *Variable Gapped* LCSP (VGLCSP), introduced in [8] and theoretically examined in [2], and experimentally in [**?**]. This problem extends the standard LCSP by imposing flexible distance limits ("gaps") between consecutive symbols in the resulting subsequence, allowing these gaps to vary along the input sequences.

Formally, for each input sequence $s_i \in S$, a gap function $G_{s_i} \colon \{1, \ldots, |s_i|\} \mapsto \mathbb{N}$ defines the maximum distance allowed between the positions of appearances of consecutive characters for resulting common subsequence in s_i. That is, if the characters of a subsequence s appear at the positions $i_i^1 < \ldots < i_i^{|s|}$ in s_i, the gap constraint is satisfied iff $i_i^x - i_i^{x-1} \leq G_{s_i}[i_i^x] + 1$ for each $x = 2, \ldots, |s|$. A common subsequence s is considered feasible if the corresponding gap constraints hold across all $s_i \in S$. The VGLCSP represents a flexible and realistic model of sequence alignment, which is particularly useful for comparing DNA or protein sequences with variable structural distances, but also in time series analysis, especially in settings where events are required to occur within specified temporal delays [5].

Although exact dynamic programming approaches exist for two-sequence case ($m = 2$) scenario [7], their computational complexity becomes prohibitive for larger m. To the best of our knowledge, no effective exact and only one approximate approaches for general m, a clearly NP-hard problem. The only existing approximate approach is an iterative beam search [**?**]. This methodology is built on the state-space problem representation and introduced space of root nodes. Each such node is explored in both ways via beam search: expanding current partial solution first by feasibly appending a sequence as its prefix, and subsequently, in another beam search call, feasibly extending that solution by concatenating letter-by-letter to its tail. At each iterations, new candidates for root nodes are detected and added in the candidate queue. Given that the methodology provides a scalable alternative to inefficient exact methods, this approach provided first results in the literature for arbitrary number of input sequences m. On the other hand, the approach relies on the use of several known hand-crafted (upper bound) heuristics for which there is an evidence from the LCS problem literature that they may offer poor guidance when m is large of Σ is small [1]. In the presence of gap constraints, it could be even worsen. The second detected research gap concerns lack of practically-motivated instances for the tackled problem as only synthetic instances are generated so far. Driven by these questions, the first gap is filled by designing a learning iterative beam search, which combines hand-crafted search guidance and the learned guidance into a superior one. To learn a search heuristic, an iterative approach is performed, able to learn the guidance in the iterative beam search approach. Shortly, the heuristic score for each node is represented as an outcome of multi-layered neural network derived in a layer-by-layer forward pass. The weights of neural network model are evolved by a genetic algorithm. The COP literature is known by utilizing similar (hybrid) methodology when learning heuristics, for example in [3] for the restricted LCS, [9] for the square LCS problem, or [10] for routing problems, to name a few. The difference between these is that their learned heuristics are not further combined with others as we did here into one ensemble method. To address the second research gap, we have derived practically-motivated problem instances by taking (two) biologically-motivated benchmark sets from LCS literature, and generating energy-aware gap constraints at each position of inherited input sequences.

Contributions. This work utilizes a framework for constructing a data-driven heuristic to guide the iterative beam search, specifically designed in the context of the *Variable Gapped Longest Common Subsequence Problem* (VGLCSP). A feed-forward neural network (FFNN) is used to parameterize the heuristic score of each node in the beam search. Instead of relying on gradient-based training, which is shown effective for the (constrained) continuous problems, the network weights are optimized using a Genetic Algorithm (GA), in particular the popular biased RKGA (BRKGA) approach. Note that here we deal with a fully non-differentiable search space when training this ML model. To establish synergy between two complementary scores, the outcome of the trained neural network and hand-crafted heuristics, a novel ensemble heuristic is introduced. This

novel ensemble heuristic is clearly a new state-of-the-art guidance, according to the echausive experimental evaluation. The second contribution is the introduction of the first real-world benchmark set fo the tackled problem. In this case-scenario, gap constraints are designed to reflect on local thermodynamic stability estimated via nearest-neighbor interaction around each nucleotide.

The paper is organized as follows. TODO

2 Iterative Multi-Source Beam Search for GLCS Problem

TODO

3 Utilizing Feed-Forward Neural Networks for Guiding the Search

The heuristic is represented by a *multi-layer perceptron* with an arbitrary number of hidden layers and user-defined units per layer. Supported activation functions include `hyperbolic tangent`, `ReLU`, and `sigmoid`.

For each layer l, forward propagation is defined as:

$$\mathbf{z}^{(l+1)} = W^{(l)}\mathbf{a}^{(l)} + b^{(l)}, \quad \mathbf{a}^{(l+1)} = \phi(\mathbf{z}^{(l+1)}),$$

where $W^{(l)}$ and $b^{(l)}$ are the weight matrix and bias vector, respectively, and ϕ denotes the activation function.

All weights and biases are flattened into a single vector, which forms the chromosome of a GA individual.

3.1 Fitness Evaluation

Given a candidate weight vector:

1. The weights are loaded into the FFNN.
2. IMSBS is executed on each training instance using the neural heuristic (guiding the search in the forward iterations as more sensible than the backward iterations).
3. The size of the best sequence obtained for each instance is recorded.

The fitness value is computed as the average solution quality over all training instances. Validation performance is computed analogously on a separate dataset and is used only for reporting.

(Q0) Speed up – evaluate fitness value by using parallelization.

3.2 Feature Extraction for the Variable-Gap LCS

To guide the search process, each partial solution (node) is represented by a fixed-length numerical feature vector capturing both the current state of the construction and the structure of the remaining search space. These features are designed to be instance-independent and comparable across problem sizes.

Let $S = \{s_1, \ldots, s_k\}$ denote the set of input sequences, and let p_i be the current matched position in sequence s_i at a given node. The vector $\mathbf{p}^L = (p_1, \ldots, p_k)$ is first normalized by the corresponding sequence lengths,

$$p_i \leftarrow \frac{p_i}{|s_i|},$$

so that progress in each sequence lies in $[0, 1]$ and becomes independent of absolute input sizes.

From this normalized position vector, four statistical descriptors are extracted: maximum, minimum, mean, and standard deviation (4 features). These quantities characterize, respectively, the most advanced and least advanced sequences, the average depth of the search, and the imbalance of progress among sequences. In addition, *the current length of the partially constructed subsequence* is included as a feature (as the fifth feature). Together, these values provide a compact description of the current search state.

To capture the feasibility of future extensions, gap-related features are computed from the positions of remaining sequences (subproblem) of input sequences. For each sequence s_i, all gap bounds associated with positions strictly after the current node position are collected. Symbolically, for each v, Gap_i^{min} is calculated as $\min\{G_i(j) \mid j = p_i^L, i = 1, \ldots, m\}$, Gap_i^{max} is calculated as $\max\{G_i(j) \mid j = p_i^L, i = 1, \ldots, m\}$, Gap_i^{avg} as $\mathrm{AVG}\{G_i(j) \mid j = p_i^L, i = 1, \ldots, m\}$, and Gap_i^{std} as $\mathrm{STD}\{G_i(j) \mid j = p_i^L, i = 1, \ldots, m\}$, where $G_1, \ldots, G_m$ are gap constraints associated to $s_1, \ldots, s_m$ respectively speed up the calc. of G-stats – preprocessing... . This gives us additionally 4 features; in overall 9 features are used for the **feature configuration 1** (F1). These statistics for gap constrains summarize the remaining flexibility of the instance: large average or maximum gaps indicate greater freedom for future matches, whereas small minimum gaps and large variability typically signal tighter constraints and increased difficulty. Additional feature $|\Sigma|$, this 10 features, created the **feature configuration 2** (F2); When adding m (number of input sequences) to F2, we obtain **feature configuration 3** (F3). (Q1) uestion: s there a need for normalization of gap values of respective subproblem... (Q2) other features?

The alphabet size $|\Sigma|$ and the number of sequences (m) as the attributes provide global structural information about the instance and help the learning model adapt to varying problem scales.

Finally, all features are standardized to zero mean and unit variance prior to being passed to the learning component. The utilization of normalization is know to contribute decreased sensibility of learning process when ML models are trained. Overall, the resulting representation combines information about (i) the current construction progress, (ii) the remaining gap-constraint landscape,

and (iii) global instance properties, yielding between 9 and 11 features depending on the configuration. This compact yet expressive encoding enables effective learning-based guidance of the search for high-quality variable-gap longest common subsequences.

4 Genetic Algorithm

The optimization process follows a population-based evolutionary scheme.

4.1 Initialization

Each individual is initialized by sampling weights uniformly from a predefined interval $[-w, w]$ (the value w parametrized, but fixed to 1).

4.2 Elitism

A fixed number of top-performing individuals are copied unchanged into the next generation.

4.3 Mutation

Several individuals are generated completely at random (random immigrants). This mechanism promotes exploration and maintains population diversity.

4.4 Offspring Generation

Three alternative parent-selection strategies are supported:

- **RKGA**: Two parents are selected uniformly at random, and each gene is inherited from either parent with probability 0.5.
- **BRKGA**: One parent is selected from the elite set and one from the non-elite set. Each gene is inherited from the elite parent with a predefined probability.
- **Lexicase Selection**: Training instances are randomly shuffled. Individuals are filtered iteratively by retaining those achieving the best performance on each instance. Parents are selected randomly from the remaining candidates.

We opt to use the *BRKGA* as the first option to work well.

4.5 Replacement and Termination

The new population consists of elites, mutants, and offspring. The algorithm terminates once a predefined time limit is reached (in this case we used 2 hours). The best individual encountered during training is continuously tracked and stored. (Q3) Terminate immediately when the validation value is decreased?

5 Overall Learning Procedure

The learning process alternates between evolutionary optimization of network weights and evaluation through (iterative multi-source) Beam Search. Importantly, the neural network does not directly predict solutions; instead, it learns how to *guide* the search procedure. This places the method within the class of neuro-evolutionary hyper-heuristics.

6 Algorithm

Algorithm 1 GA-Based Learning of a Beam Search Heuristic

```
Initialize population P with random neural network weights
Evaluate all individuals on training set T
Store best solution θ*
start ← current time
while time limit T_max has not exceeded do
    Sort P by fitness (descending) // Section 2.1
    Initialize empty population P'
    Copy top n_elites individuals from P to P'
    for i = 1 to n_mutants do
        Create random individual x
        Evaluate x on T
        Add x to P'
        Update θ* if improved
    end for
    for i = 1 to n_offspring do
        Select parents using RKGA, BRKGA, or Lexicase
        Generate offspring by crossover
        Evaluate offspring on T
        Add offspring to P'
        Update θ* if improved
    end for
    P ← P'
end while
return best weights θ*
```

6.1 Explanation of the GA-Based Learning Procedure

The proposed algorithm employs a Genetic Algorithm (GA) to learn the parameters of a neural network that guides a beam search heuristic. The objective is to optimize a parameter vector θ, representing the neural network weights, such that the induced heuristic achieves high performance on a given training set $T = \{I_1, I_2, \ldots, I_m\}$ of problem instances.

Initialization. The procedure starts by generating an initial population P of candidate solutions, where each individual corresponds to a randomly initialized set of neural network weights. All individuals are evaluated on the training set T, yielding a fitness value that reflects the quality of the corresponding heuristic. The best-performing individual found so far is stored as θ^*.

Fitness Function. Let $\mathcal{B}(I, \theta)$ denote the solution obtained by applying a beam search guided by parameters θ on instance I. Let $f(\cdot)$ be a problem-specific objective function (e.g., solution quality or cost). The fitness of an individual θ is defined as:

$$F(\theta) = \frac{1}{|T|} \sum_{I \in T} f\big(\mathcal{B}(I, \theta)\big). \tag{1}$$

Depending on the problem formulation, f can represent either a maximization objective (e.g., solution value) or a minimization objective (e.g., cost), in which case an appropriate transformation is applied to ensure consistency.

Beam Search Integration. The beam search procedure maintains, at each depth level t, a set of at most k partial solutions (beam width k). Let $\mathcal{S}_t$ denote the set of candidate states at level t. For each state $s \in \mathcal{S}_t$, a feature representation $\phi(s)$ is computed and evaluated by the neural network:

$$h_\theta(s) = \mathrm{NN}_\theta(\phi(s)), \tag{2}$$

where $h_\theta(s)$ represents the heuristic score assigned to state s. The beam is then updated by selecting the top-k states according to $h_\theta(s)$:

$$\mathcal{S}_{t+1} = \mathrm{Top}_k \left\{ s' \mid s' \in \mathrm{Expand}(\mathcal{S}_t),\ h_\theta(s') \right\}. \tag{3}$$

This process continues until a terminal state is reached, yielding the final solution $\mathcal{B}(I, \theta)$.

Evolutionary Process. The algorithm iteratively improves the population until a predefined time limit $T_{\max}$ is reached. At each iteration, the population is sorted in descending order of fitness. A new population P' is constructed using three mechanisms:

- **Elitism.** A fixed number n_{elites} of top-performing individuals are directly copied from P to P', preserving the best solutions.
- **Mutation (Random Immigrants).** A set of $n_{mutants}$ individuals is generated randomly to introduce diversity. Each is evaluated using $F(\theta)$ and added to P', updating θ^* if improved.
- **Crossover (Recombination).** The remaining $n_{offspring}$ individuals are generated via recombination. Parents are selected using strategies such as RKGA, BRKGA, or Lexicase selection. Offspring inherit characteristics from both parents, are evaluated, and added to P', with updates to θ^* if necessary.

Population Update and Termination. After generating all individuals, the population is updated as $P \leftarrow P'$. The process repeats until the time limit $T_{\max}$ is reached. The algorithm returns the best solution θ^*, corresponding to the neural network weights that induce the most effective beam search heuristic on the training set.

Key Properties.

- **Exploration–Exploitation Balance:** The combination of elitism, mutation, and crossover ensures both intensification and diversification.
- **Gradient-Free Optimization:** The approach does not rely on gradient information and is suitable for non-differentiable objectives.
- **Anytime Behavior:** The best solution θ^* is continuously updated and available at any point during execution.

As the best optimizer, the BRKGA setting used in training: $n_{pop} = 20, n_{elites} = 1, p_e = 0.5, p_m = 7$.

7 Discussion

The proposed framework learns heuristics rather than explicit solutions. The neural network is optimized exclusively through downstream search performance, enabling learning in non-differentiable settings. This tightly coupled integration of evolutionary learning and the classical optimization algorithm Beam Search allows the system to adapt its guidance strategy to the structure of the problem instances.

8 Preliminary results

IMSBS setting (grid search used for tuning the algorithm):

- $\beta = 1000$, $h' = h5$, $\#imbs_iters = 1000, \#num_roots = 10$

Learning IMSBS setting uses the same setting, to be completely fair with the comparison. The neural network configuration in this case, obtained after running several 2-layer (n_1, n_2) and 3-layer configurations (n_1, n_2, n_3) for $n_1, n_2, n_3 \in \{5, 10\}$ (neurons) and $n_1 \geq n_2 \geq n_3$. We set up the same activation function in all layers choosing among the three (most) known $\{$`tanh`, `ReLU`, `sigmoid`$\}$. The best one uses `ReLU` at each layer, and besides instance-based features, it additionally incorporate the size of alphabet Σ (F2). The configurations of NNs are obtained only after 2 hours of training is a 3-layer perception with 10 neurons each.

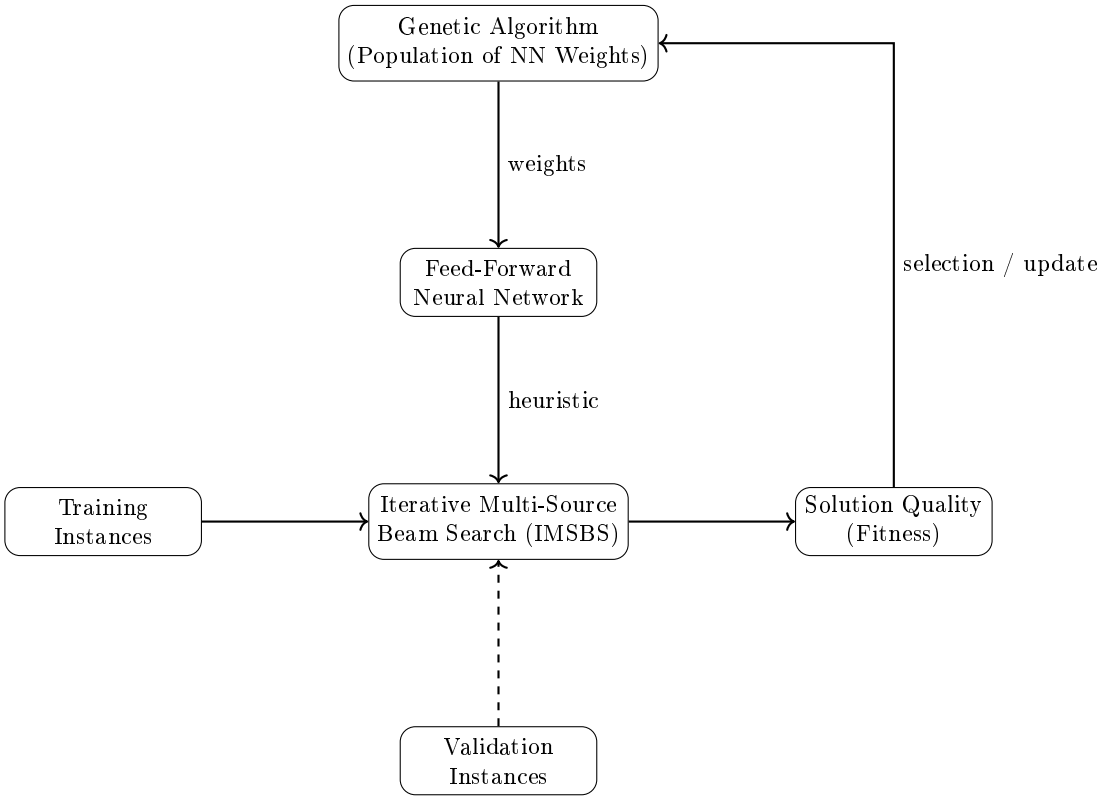

Fig. 1. Learning framework integrating a Genetic Algorithm with Iterative Multi-Source Beam Search (IMSBS). The GA evolves neural network weights. For each individual, the FFNN provides a heuristic used by IMSBS on training instances. The resulting solution quality defines fitness, which drives evolutionary selection. Validation instances are used only for monitoring generalization.

9 Conclusions

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Table 1. Comparison of objective values between IMSBS and LIMSBS. Best results per instance category are in bold.

m	n	$\|\Sigma\|$	IMSBS	LIMSBS
2	50	2	**37.7**	**37.7**
2	50	4	**30.1**	29.7
2	100	2	**72.9**	72.5
2	100	4	**61.7**	60.3
2	200	2	**139.7**	139.3
2	200	4	**125.2**	120.9
2	500	2	281.9	**295.4**
2	500	4	**302.9**	285.4
3	50	2	**31.2**	**31.2**
3	50	4	**22.9**	**22.9**
3	100	2	**58.5**	**58.5**
3	100	4	**48.5**	48.0
3	200	2	**106.3**	103.4
3	200	4	**97.4**	95.6
3	500	2	133.5	**143.1**
3	500	4	**230.3**	218.8

m	n	$\|\Sigma\|$	IMSBS	LIMSBS
5	50	2	**20.5**	**20.5**
5	50	4	**15.3**	**15.3**
5	100	2	**31.5**	31.0
5	100	4	25.9	**26.9**
5	200	2	35.2	**41.6**
5	200	4	34.0	**37.2**
5	500	2	31.0	**39.3**
5	500	4	36.3	**46.2**
10	50	2	**11.4**	11.2
10	50	4	**7.1**	**7.1**
10	100	2	10.5	**12.0**
10	100	4	7.6	**8.9**
10	200	2	11.8	**12.2**
10	200	4	7.6	**8.2**
10	500	2	12.5	**12.9**
10	500	4	7.5	**8.3**

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